

Innocent Chilongo

SOMMELIER

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Luxury hospitality sommelier with distinguished experience across prestigious wine estates and high-end fine dining. Proven track record in driving beverage revenue growth through premium wine and drinks package upselling while delivering exceptional guest experiences. Skilled in wine education and tasting experiences, premium service standards, cellar management, inventory control, and operational efficiency. Polished communicator with a refined guest first approach, deep product knowledge and professionalism. Trusted to elevate service, boost spend, and protect luxury brand standards always

EXPERIENCE

Sommelier

AUG 2021 — PRESENT

Plaisir Wine Estate

- Deliver immersive wine tasting experiences by showcasing Plaisir's award-winning wines, emphasizing estate-specific terroir, sustainable farming practices, and the winemaking philosophy to educate and engage guests.
- Customize wine recommendations based on guest preferences, enhancing satisfaction and driving direct-to-consumer sales and wine club sign-ups.
- Collaborate closely with the sales and marketing teams to develop storytelling-driven content for tastings, private events, and digital campaigns, reinforcing Plaisir's brand identity and increasing visibility.
- Manage and execute private events, including cellar tours and wine-pairing dinners, ensuring seamless logistics and elevated guest experiences that reflect Plaisir's luxury standards.
- Lead junior tasting room staff in service excellence, product knowledge, and upselling techniques, maintaining consistency in premium hospitality.
- Monitor and control stock levels, glassware, and cellar presentation to maintain Plaisir's impeccable service standards and operational readiness.
- Promote Bartenney's commitment to sustainability and biodiversity through storytelling during tastings and tours, reinforcing the estate's position as a leader in eco-conscious winemaking.

Wine Steward

DEC 2019 — MAR 2020

Le Franschhoek Hotel & Spa

- Drive beverage revenue through strategic upselling of wine, spirits and cocktails during Lunch and Dinner time.
- Deliver premium wine service and pairing recommendations to elevate guest dining experience.
- Upsell after-dinner beverages (digestifs, liqueurs, premium spirits) to increase venue sales targets.
- Support daily service operations across breakfast, lunch, and dinner including hot beverages and bar service.
- Prioritized a customer-first approach, ensuring active sales promotion focusing on guest satisfaction.

EDUCATION

Certificate in Wine

2021-10

Cape Wine Academy, Stellenbosch

Level 2

2021-11 – 2026-02

Wine and Spirit Educational Trust (WSET)

SKILLS

Wine Expertise

Food and Wine Pairing

Customer Service Excellence

Inventory Management

Communication and Storytelling

CERTIFICATIONS

Certificate in Wine

Cape Wine Academy, Stellenbosch · 2021

Level 2

Wine and Spirit Educational Trust (WSET) · 2021-2026

HOSPITALITY PROFILE

Service styles Fine dining

Wine knowledge Advanced